

HEIST AWARDS '26

Winners Brochure

Brought to you by

HAVAS People

A Havas Company

www.heistawards.com

@heistawards

WHAT A YEAR

Over the past year, you have invested your expertise, creativity and energy into supporting students and strengthening their connection with higher education.

From developing standout campaigns and experiences to building lasting relationships, your work has made a meaningful difference at every stage of the student journey.

The challenges have been significant, but so too have the achievements. Through changing priorities, increasing expectations and an evolving landscape, you have continued to innovate, adapt and deliver.

These awards are a recognition of that commitment and impact. We hope they serve as a reminder of the value of your work and the difference it makes to students, colleagues and the wider sector.

The categories

Have a browse through our award categories and click to see our Gold, Silver, Bronze and Highly Commended entries.

1. **Best Undergraduate Student Recruitment Campaign >>**
2. **Best Postgraduate Student Recruitment Campaign >>**
3. **Best International Campaign or Initiative >>**
4. **Best Use of Video >>**
5. **Best Use of Content >>**
6. **Innovative Use of Technology >>**
7. **Most Effective use of Social Media >>**
8. **Best Brand/Reputation Campaign >>**
9. **Best Event Experience >>**
10. **Best Widening Participation Initiative >>**
11. **Best Use of Data, Insight or Marketing Research >>**
12. **Best Community/Business Engagement Campaign >>**
13. **Best Student or Alumni Engagement Initiative >>**
14. **Best Prospective Student Journey/Experience >>**
15. **Collaboration of the Year >>**
16. **Rising Star Award >>**
17. **Marketing Team of the Year >>**

Best Undergraduate Student Recruitment Campaign

Sponsored by



Handed to the best campaign that attracts undergraduate students to apply and enrol for courses.

GOLD | SILVER | BRONZE

Gold Award

Best Undergraduate Student Recruitment Campaign

University College Birmingham

UCB Collaboration with Aktar Islam



UCB partnered with Michelin-starred chef Aktar Islam to reverse declining culinary enrolments through authentic industry-led storytelling. The campaign combined OOH advertising, social media and video content across multiple platforms. It exceeded all objectives, achieving 43% enrolment growth across the 2 courses, 88% geographical expansion, and a 13.5:1 ROI (year 1).

Let's hear from the judges

"This campaign stood out for its authentic and values-driven approach, with judges praising the meaningful collaboration with alumnus Aktar Islam and the powerful storytelling at its heart. Tackling a clearly defined challenge with innovation, a commitment to diversity and measurable impact, it delivered what our judges described as 'all the right ingredients' for success."

Best Undergraduate Student Recruitment Campaign

Silver Award

Manchester Metropolitan University

This is Manchester Met 2025

Manchester Met's 2025 undergraduate campaign tackled recruitment risk head on - reshaping early demand, maximising conversion, and growing intake from London and the South East while protecting the North West's share. An integrated, student-first strategy exceeded challenging targets, reduced Clearing reliance, and built a sustainable, resilient model for future growth.

Let's hear from the judges

"Judges recognised this as a highly strategic campaign, built on strong research, clearly defined audiences and excellent operational delivery. They were particularly impressed by its ambitious move to reduce reliance on Clearing, alongside outstanding results, clear ROI and a strong commitment to sustainability and accessibility."



Bronze Award

Queen's University Belfast

Closer Than You Think

This undergraduate campaign tackled a clear conversion barrier in Great Britain, where awareness of Queen's was undermined by perceptions of distance. Using applicant insight and feeder school data, they combined authentic student storytelling with hyper-targeted media to reframe accessibility and value. They drove year-on-year growth in applications and offers, all within budget.

Let's hear from the judges

"This was praised as a clever and memorable response to a clearly defined challenge, overcoming perceptions of distance through relatable and localised student storytelling. Judges admired the creativity of the concept, the strength of the targeting and the campaign's ability to deliver against its objectives in a focused and effective way."



Best Postgraduate Student Recruitment Campaign

Sponsored by

Find University
A KEYSTONE COMPANY

Handed to the best campaign that attracts postgraduate students to apply and enrol for courses.

GOLD | SILVER | BRONZE

Gold Award

Best Postgraduate Student Recruitment Campaign

University of Southampton

Bring Your Perspective. Let's Change The World.



University of Southampton's PGR campaign reimagined postgraduate research for a UK audience. Spotlighting diverse voices and celebrating unconventional journeys, it transformed curiosity into action. Through bold visuals, authentic stories and inclusive outreach, they amplified visibility and inspired new communities to see themselves as researchers. The campaign sparked a measurable uplift in applications and offers.

Let's hear from the judges

"Southampton set out to transform perceptions of postgraduate research by making it feel more relatable, accessible and achievable. The judges praised the campaign's excellent use of insight, journey-mapping, strong full-funnel strategy and commitment to inclusion, recognising that it delivered impressive results and established a strong long-term model for growth."

Best Postgraduate Student Recruitment Campaign

Silver Award

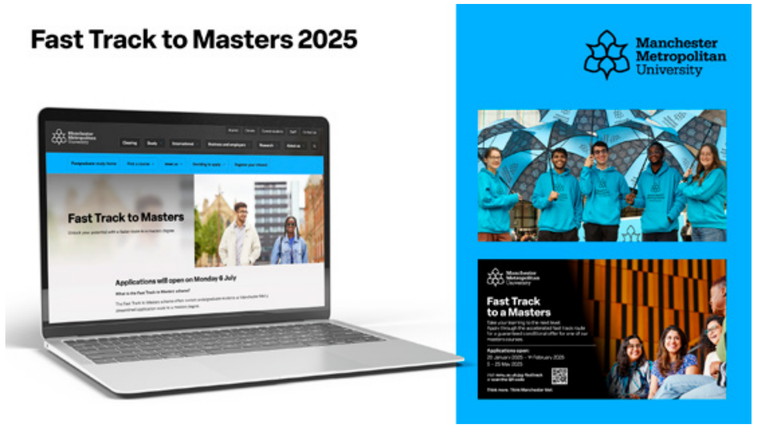
Manchester Metropolitan University

Fast Track to Masters 2025

Manchester Met's 'Fast Track to Masters' scheme reversed declining postgraduate progression through insight-led process innovation, introducing a clear, accessible pathway to postgraduate study. The scheme exceeded application targets by 65% and increased the number of undergraduate students progressing to postgraduate study, delivering a scalable, cost-effective model for sustainable growth.

Let's hear from the judges

"This is an exceptionally strong entry because it solves a real institutional problem in a practical, high-impact way, backed up with genuinely standout results. The campaign tackled structural barriers to UG-to-PG progression and solved it in a simple but very effective way."



Bronze Award

Manchester Metropolitan University

Research Today. Transform Tomorrow.

Through its first institution-wide postgraduate research recruitment campaign, Manchester Met challenged sector perceptions through insight-driven, inclusive storytelling that reimagined who belongs in research. The campaign broadened appeal, strengthened confidence in research pathways, and delivered exceptional early impact. It achieved the university's projected year three recruitment target within its first year.

Let's hear from the judges

"A very strong first institution-wide postgraduate research campaign, this entry combined inclusive storytelling with excellent performance. Judges congratulated its understanding of audience perceptions, the thoughtful creative approach and outstanding results, creating one of the most complete and well-rounded campaigns in the category."



Best International Campaign or Initiative

Sponsored by



Handed to the best campaign or initiative that connects with students, alumni or staff on a global stage.

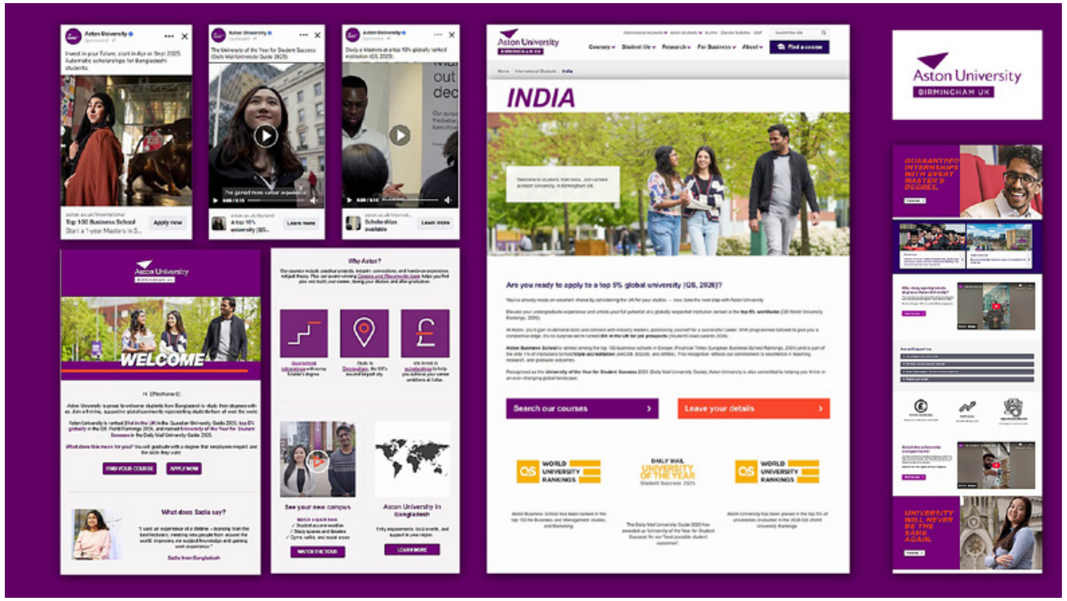
GOLD | SILVER | BRONZE

Gold Award

Best International Campaign or Initiative

Aston University

Built, Not Inherited - Aston's Data-Led Spring Recruitment Breakthrough



Limited brand legacy. A £10k budget. A challenging visa landscape. Without historical momentum, they built a high-performing Spring recruitment framework from scratch - conducting their own research and crafting a proposition that flexed for every market. The message was consistent; the execution was personal. The result? 357% enrolment growth.

Let's hear from the judges

"A double whammy for Aston! This is a technically outstanding submission that demonstrates what rigorous in-house research, precision targeting and full-funnel consistency can achieve on a very modest budget. The data methodology is the most sophisticated in this category, the ROI calculation is the most transparent, and the results are exceptional."

Best International Campaign or Initiative

Silver Award

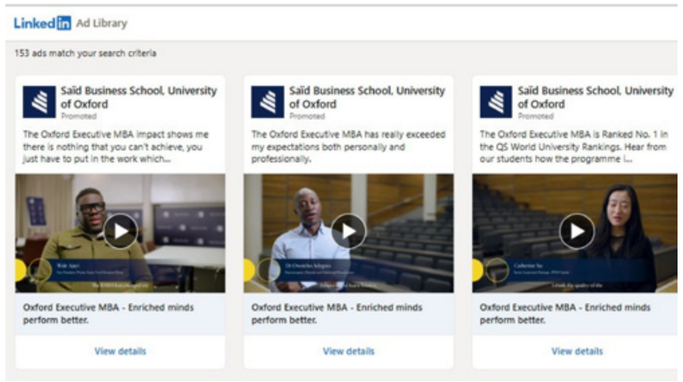
Saïd Business School, University of Oxford & Bray Leino

Repositioning the Oxford Executive MBA for Global Diversity and Growth

The Oxford Executive MBA's 'Enriched Minds' campaign repositioned the programme as a transformative, internationally diverse leadership experience. Insight-led and people-focused, it amplified authentic student and alumni voices across global channels, driving full enrolment, increased female participation, and record engagement. It truly demonstrated how purpose-driven storytelling builds brand trust and sustainable recruitment growth.

Let's hear from the judges

"This is an excellent submission that demonstrates genuine insight-led strategic thinking and well-researched creative decisions that clearly resonated with a sophisticated international audience. The results are exceptional and EDI considerations are clearly embedded into the strategy."



Bronze Award

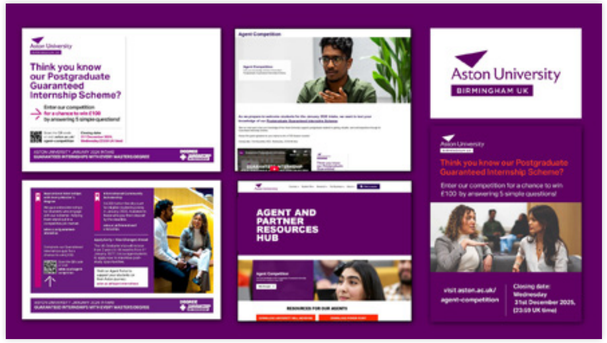
Aston University

Unchartered Territory: A Bold B2B Campaign That Re-Energised International Recruitment

While the sector navigated unprecedented uncertainty, Aston University challenged higher education marketing convention - piloting a creative, multi-channel B2B campaign that targeted its global agent network. Gamification, physical mail, WhatsApp amplification, and a digital resource hub combined to exceed every target and deliver a 95:1 ROI.

Let's hear from the judges

"In a category where most submissions focus on B2C recruitment marketing, this campaign's decision to treat agents as a primary marketing audience and to do so creatively was great to see. The judges felt the channel mix was inventive, the data foundation was sound, and the results were exceptional relative to the investment."



Best Use of Video

Sponsored by

HAVAS People
A Havas Company

This award recognises the innovative and impactful use of video to engage and inspire audiences.

GOLD | SILVER | BRONZE

Gold Award

Best Use of Video

London South Bank University

Make Yourself At Home



By trusting cinematic storytelling to spark genuine connection, 'Make Yourself At Home' is not just a recruitment video, but a benchmark for how universities can build brand affinity with a generation demanding relatability, entertainment, and human storytelling. This was a video anchored in real stories, developed with - and for - LSBU students.

Let's hear from the judges

"The judges loved this video, which featured ambitious drone cinematography, giving viewers an immersive, dynamic experience of undergraduate life while seamlessly weaving in key messages and institutional strengths. Ambitious, well-executed, and genuinely memorable - a true stand out!"

Best Use of Video

Silver Award

Aston University & Waterfall

Yazan - Rewrite What's Possible

This stunning film elevates and redefines student storytelling. You don't just watch it - you feel it! The team used cinematic techniques and developed a powerful and personal narrative with Yazan, so he could tell his compelling story. It was a journey that epitomised their strategy and student proposition - Inclusive, Entrepreneurial and Transformational.

Let's hear from the judges

"Yazan: Rewrite What's Possible is a high-quality, emotionally resonant submission that combines genuine cinematic ambition with strong strategic grounding and exceptional results."



Bronze Award

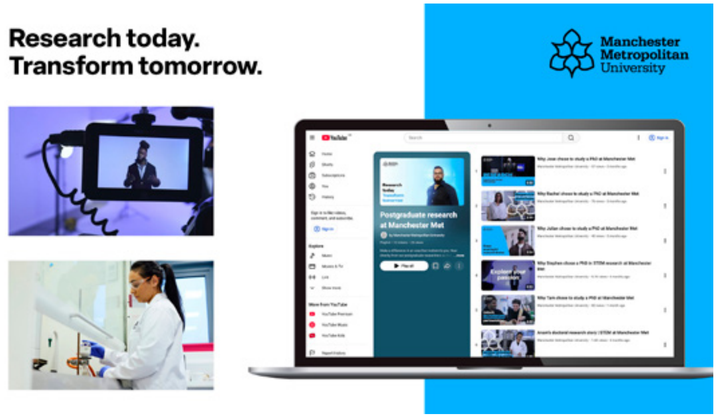
Manchester Metropolitan University

Research Today. Transform Tomorrow.

Manchester Met set out to grow research intensity by boosting the visibility and appeal of postgraduate research in a competitive, often intimidating market. A video-led campaign using authentic, unscripted student voices reframed who research is for, humanised the experience and built trust. They exceeded year three recruitment targets in year one.

Let's hear from the judges

"The judges found this to be sector-leading work that sets a genuine benchmark for research marketing in higher education. It highlights the authentic experience of PhD students and reframes research study as accessible rather than elite."



Best Use of Content

Sponsored by



Handed to the campaign that shows the best use of innovation and creative thinking.

GOLD | SILVER | BRONZE

Gold Award

Best Use of Content

Loughborough University

Making The World's Smallest Violin



Loughborough University's PR team turned a complex nanolithography launch into a playful global story by creating the 'world's smallest violin'. Their zero-budget mix of video, images, and written content made advanced physics accessible, sparking widespread interest and generating over 200 pieces of media coverage worldwide.

Let's hear from the judges

"This is a standout content entry. Loughborough University took what could have been a niche research infrastructure announcement and turned it into a genuinely memorable, accessible and globally shareable science story."

Best Use of Content

Silver Award

University of East London

East London Arts

The University of East London launched East London Arts, a unified creative sub-brand tackling a decline in arts recruitment. Through a multi-channel content strategy spanning social media, campaign films, web and live events, they exceeded every objective. They achieved 2.37M impressions, 348 Open Day attendees and a 4.7% application uplift.

Let's hear from the judges

"With an impressive use of data, this is an extremely compelling entry. The submission actually brings the idea, visual world and content ecosystem to life."



Bronze Award

University of East London

AI-Ready Content

With prospective students no longer relying solely on traditional search, UEL aimed to redesign recruitment content architecture around real student intent. They embedded structured, accessible FAQs within priority pages. By aligning human need with machine understanding, they ensured UEL remains visible, accessible and trusted in an AI-driven world.

Let's hear from the judges

"A forward-thinking entry that responds directly to how students are now searching for information. The focus on rebuilding content around real questions, and making it accessible for both users and AI platforms, is very relevant in the current climate."



Innovative Use of Technology

Sponsored by

Anything is Possible

This category celebrates excellence in the use of technology to attract and engage potential students.

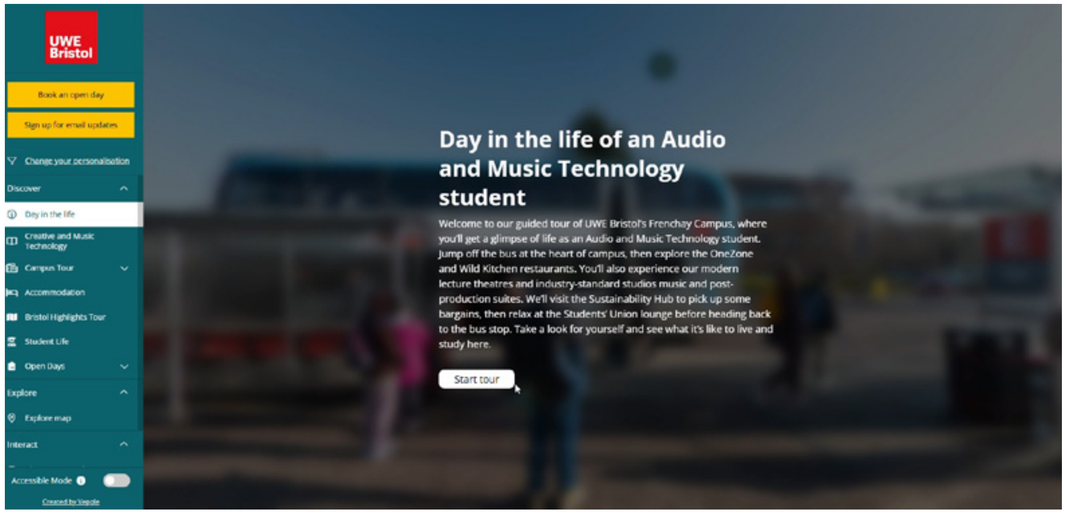
GOLD | SILVER | BRONZE

Gold Award

Innovative Use of Technology

UWE Bristol & Vepple

Redefining Discovery Through Immersive Tech



UWE Bristol achieved a bold, sector-first strategic pivot by retiring the traditional digital prospectus and positioning its immersive virtual tour as the primary discovery platform. This streamlined, digital-first approach delivered a world-class £3.19 cost per lead, a 969% increase in prospective student leads, and an extraordinary 12.5x improvement in ROI.

Let's hear from the judges

"Judges applauded this bold and confident move away from the traditional digital prospectus, using technology in a genuinely innovative way to transform student discovery. Backed by strong insight, excellent use of data and outstanding results, this project demonstrates how technology can deliver both greater efficiency and greater impact. A real worthy winner!"

Innovative Use of Technology

Silver Award

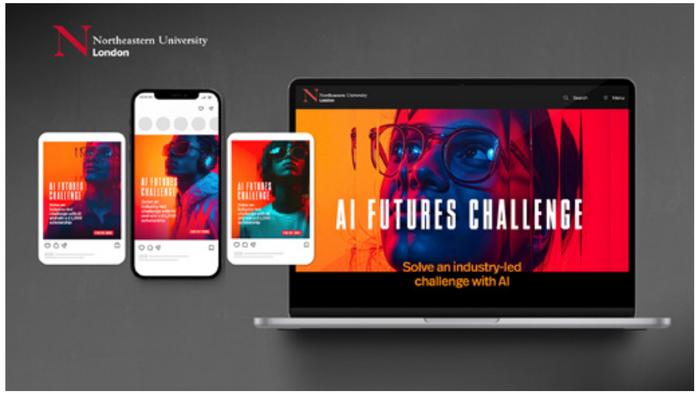
Northeastern University London

AI Futures Challenge at Northeastern University London

The 'AI Futures Challenge' is a five-day online programme where Year 12 students tackled a real business problem set by Lyra AI, a startup within NU London's Startup Hub. The programme helped students integrate AI tools into their creative process and develop the work skills their futures will require.

Let's hear from the judges

"This entry impressed judges with its timely and innovative response to a real-world challenge, creating genuine value for students while helping to strengthen the future recruitment pipeline. With a compelling proposition, strong supporting evidence and the potential for long-term impact, it demonstrated how technology can be used in meaningful and creative ways."



Bronze Award

De Montfort University

DMUniverse

'DMUniverse' reimagines how prospective students experience university before arrival. Designed for early pipeline learners, it addresses a core sector challenge: engaging digitally native audiences who expect immersive, personalised experiences when making life decisions. DMUniverse is a fully explorable virtual campus where players discover courses, careers and student life through gameplay.

Let's hear from the judges

"Judges praised DMUniverse as a creative, engaging and memorable use of technology that makes higher education more accessible to young people. Developed through strong co-creation with schools and delivered on a modest budget, it showed impressive potential as a scalable and sustainable widening participation initiative."



Most Effective Use of Social Media

Sponsored by



This award recognises the most effective and innovative use of social media to achieve strategic objectives.

GOLD | SILVER | BRONZE

Gold Award

Most Effective Use of Social Media

SOAS University of London

SOAS Explains and Meet the Academics



With no paid media and a £10k budget, SOAS repositioned itself as 'The World's University' through short-form social video. Translating academic expertise into timely global conversations, the campaign generated over one million organic views. Added to that, it increased study-page traffic, and strengthened reputation among prospective students who were discovering universities globally online through social platforms.

Let's hear from the judges

"An outstanding example of social media done exceptionally well, this campaign brought academic expertise to life through accessible, engaging and platform-native content. Judges praised its ability to connect complex topics with contemporary trends, creating genuine thumb-stopping content while delivering impressive results and strengthening female representation."

Most Effective Use of Social Media

Silver Award

Northumbria University, Newcastle

Northumbria University Clearing Social Media

Northumbria University's organic clearing campaign transformed regional identity into competitive advantage, using strategic social search optimisation and quality-over-quantity content. Their "Geordie Clearing Call" achieved viral success and industry recognition. With zero budget, they dramatically exceeded all objectives, proving authentic platform-native engagement outperforms volume-based approaches in student recruitment.

Let's hear from the judges

"The judges were impressed by the way this campaign combined strategic thinking with creativity, proving the power of organic social media. Its distinctive regional voice, intelligent use of humour and strong understanding of audience behaviour created an approach that many felt the wider sector could learn from."



Bronze Award

University of Glasgow

Building a Powerful Chinese Gen Z Community on RedNote at the University of Glasgow

Building a Powerful Chinese Gen Z Community on RedNote demonstrates how a small University of Glasgow team developed a trusted, culturally fluent voice for Mandarin-speaking audiences. They managed to drive standout growth, exceptional engagement and genuine belonging through a data-led, bespoke social strategy and audience-first content. As such, they were able to deliver sector-leading results and meaningful community impact.

Let's hear from the judges

"This was recognised as a thoughtful and highly audience-led campaign that successfully engaged a new community on an emerging platform. Judges particularly praised its culturally respectful approach, effective use of Mandarin-speaking students and strong understanding of the audience it set out to serve, recognising it as a difficult and niche piece of work executed exceptionally well."



Best Brand/Reputation Campaign

Sponsored by



This category celebrates excellence in brand reputation development.

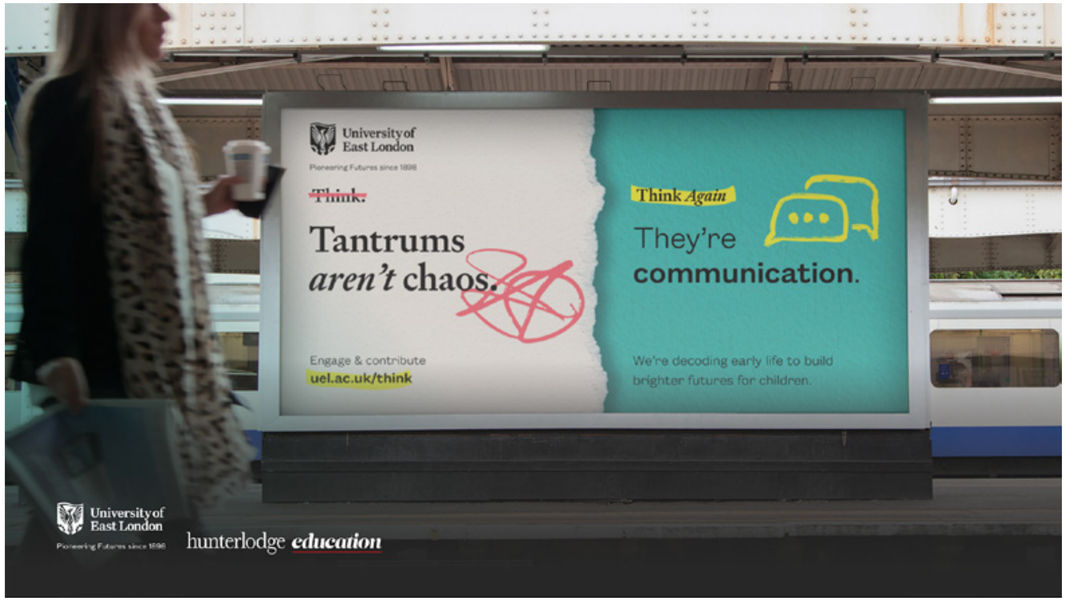
GOLD | SILVER | BRONZE

Gold Award

Best Brand/Reputation Campaign

University of East London & Hunterlodge Advertising

Think Again



UEL's 'Think Again' impact campaign transformed public perception by making their powerful research impossible to ignore. Centred on an installation about online harms, the campaign achieved a 150% uplift in search, BBC coverage, and £225,000 in new private research donations. They exceeded their objectives while making an important statement about pressing issues.

Let's hear from the judges

"This campaign showcased distinctive creativity and confident execution, shattering every target and powerfully articulating its research strengths across diverse formats, ultimately inspiring the sector to 'think again' about higher education marketing."

Best Brand/Reputation Campaign

Silver Award

University of Lancashire

That's How We Do It In Lancashire - University Name Change Brand Campaign

They didn't just change their name, they transformed their trajectory. By fusing bold, Lancashire-proud creativity with sector-leading technical execution, they protected 20 years of digital equity. They grew awareness and search visibility at record pace, and turned reputation into measurable recruitment impact. This is modern university brand transformation, done right.

Let's hear from the judges

"A distinctive campaign that faced risk head on. It combines clever messaging with humour, warmth and a sense of place. That's how they do it in Lancashire."



Bronze Award

Aston University

University Will Never Be The Same Again

Aston launched a bold new proposition to support its ambitious Aston 2030 strategy, revitalising a stagnant recruitment pipeline and declining international interest. Through deep insight, sector-leading innovations and disruptive creative, they achieved a transformational student offer that drove significant growth, elevated brand perception and delivered outstanding ROI.

Let's hear from the judges

"Judges recognised this campaign as an extraordinary example of insight-led transformation. By moving away from generic sector messaging and building a distinctive proposition grounded in evidence and audience understanding, the team delivered impressive growth in awareness, recruitment and reputation while establishing a powerful blueprint for institutional differentiation."

Aston University
BIRMINGHAM UK

Best Event Experience

Sponsored by

zestme

Handed to the event experience that best stands out from the crowd and enhances brand reputation.

GOLD | SILVER | BRONZE

Gold Award

Best Event Experience

Cardiff Metropolitan University

Get Cardiff Met Ready



‘Get Cardiff Met Ready’ is a pre-enrolment event designed to reduce anxiety, build belonging and improve transition for incoming students. Through practical sessions, peer-led activities and tailored resources, the event increased confidence, boosted attendance and improved conversion. It delivered a measurable impact on student experience, engagement and enrolment.

Let’s hear from the judges

“An excellent example of an event making a tangible difference at a critical stage in the student journey. The outcomes are excellent, particularly in terms of increased confidence, attendance and improved enrolment conversion, with strong ROI.”

Best Event Experience

Silver Award

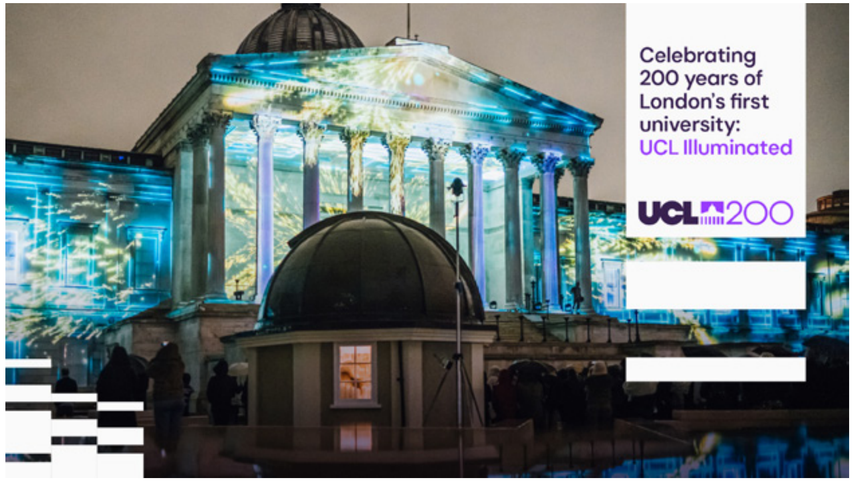
University College London

UCL Illuminated

2026 marks 200 years since UCL was founded as London's first university. To launch a year of celebrations, they transformed their 19th-century, newly redeveloped Wilkins Building into an immersive son et lumière experience that brought to life UCL's history and future.

Let's hear from the judges

"This is an exceptional and highly distinctive event that delivers a truly immersive and memorable experience. The combination of visual spectacle, narrative and interactive elements make this stand out."



Bronze Award

Manchester Metropolitan University

It Begins with an Open Day

Manchester Met transformed its undergraduate open days alongside a major brand refresh. They created an immersive, student-centred experience that improved accessibility, atmosphere and engagement. Through insight-led features, personalised communications and operational enhancements, they increased attendance, satisfaction and applications. It was a chance to showcase innovation and effective cross-university collaboration, while delivering strong recruitment outcomes.

Let's hear from the judges

"Judges were impressed by this thoughtful transformation of the open day experience, extending well beyond a single event to create a more joined-up journey for prospective students. Guided by clear insight and supported by exceptional results, the ROI calculations and brilliant explanation of pre, at event, and post event engagement stood out in this category."



Best Widening Participation Initiative

Sponsored by

The Student Room

Handed to the most innovative marketing project or activity that promotes diversity, encourages those from non-traditional backgrounds to apply, or reaches new audiences.

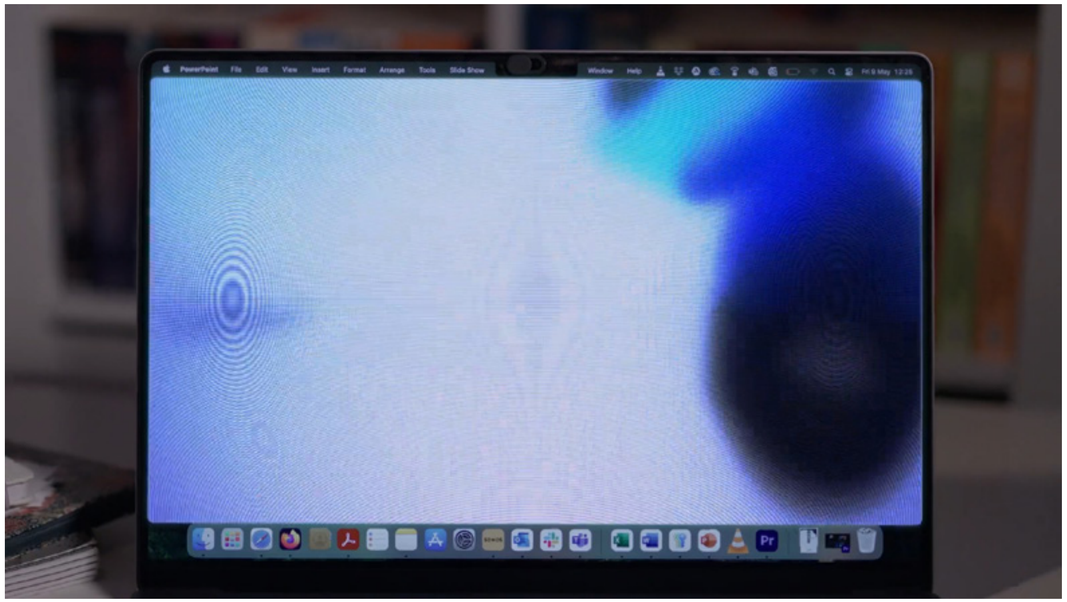
GOLD | SILVER | BRONZE

Gold Award

Best Widening Participation Initiative

Institute of Coding & Always Be Content, funded by Nominet

Click Into Place



Click Start helped underrepresented young adults see digital careers as possible, then move towards them. In its final three months, a digital-first, full-funnel campaign delivered 12,677 new learners and exceeded recruitment targets. It also improved CPA to £8.50 and supported real progression into employment - proving widening participation can be scalable, accessible and effective.

Let's hear from the judges

"A true disruptor in the Widening Participation category. The initiative featured a clear problem statement, a strong narrative, and delivered an impressive ROI, making a significant impact by reaching new audiences through innovative engagement."

Best Widening Participation Initiative

Silver Award

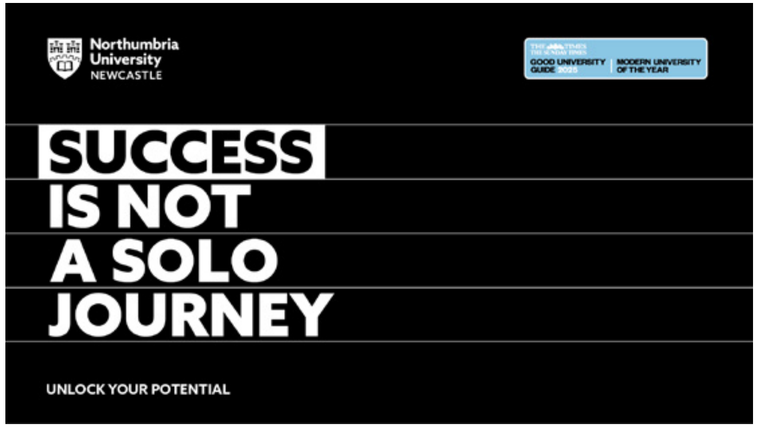
Northumbria University, Newcastle

Unlock Your Potential

Northumbria University's Unlock Your Potential campaign was built on a single conviction: that university is for everyone, regardless of postcode, grades or age. Targeting the North East, the UK's lowest HE participation region. It tackled psychological and practical barriers facing non-traditional students, driving genuine social mobility through bold, insight-led marketing.

Let's hear from the judges

"This initiative demonstrated outstanding targeting and segmentation alongside powerful, nuanced creative messaging and great content. It led to highly successful outcomes, effectively integrating with standard outreach activities to broaden access and engagement."



Bronze Award

The University of Sheffield

Beyond Events: Embedding belonging for BAME & Muslim students into the University of Sheffield's digital DNA

Transforming "Access" into "Belonging" through student-centred co-creation, the BAME & Muslim Hubs embed inclusion into the University of Sheffield's core digital infrastructure. For just £350, achieving a 78% positive sentiment rate that outperforms sector benchmarks, the Hubs provide a scalable, high-yield blueprint for sector-wide inclusive practice transcending traditional widening participation events.

Let's hear from the judges

"This highly efficient initiative set clear aims and meticulously achieved them, demonstrating a focused and effective strategy for promoting diversity and encouraging access to higher education, enabled by co-creation with students."



Best Use of Data, Insight or Marketing Research

Sponsored by



Handed to the most innovative marketing activity routed in data-driven customer and market insight.

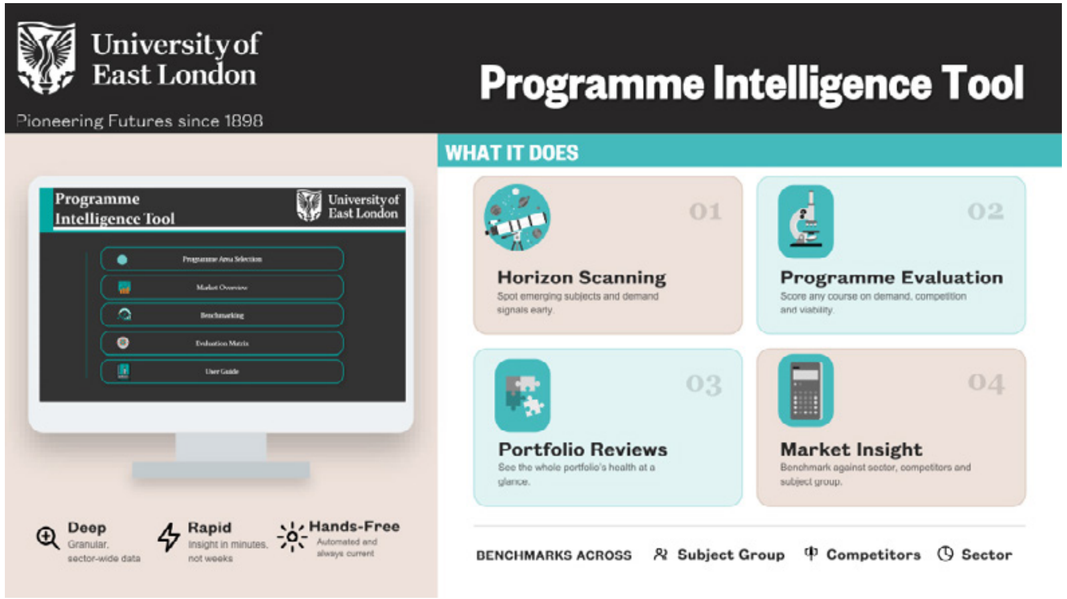
GOLD | SILVER | BRONZE

Gold Award

Best Use of Data, Insight or Marketing Research

University of East London

Programme Intelligence Tool



UEL's Programme Intelligence Tool productises HE market insight into a hands-free, automated capability. Powered by an analytical engine combining automated logic and standardised calculations, it enables cohort selection, KPI benchmarking and an Evaluation Matrix to contextualise programme areas against sector, competitor and subject baselines. Outcome: rapid, rigorous, accessible, decision-ready intelligence.

Let's hear from the judges

"This was a unanimous decision for an exceptional and technically sophisticated entry - a truly innovative programme intelligence tool driving real portfolio transformation, backed by compelling ROI and remarkable operational efficiency gains. In a highly competitive category, this was truly the standout submission and showcased a tool all the judges are jealous of."

Best Use of Data, Insight or Marketing Research

Silver Award

Aston University

Data-Driven Acceleration of Aston University's QS Academic and Employer Reputation

Aston University used QS Analytics to drive behaviour change, mobilise staff, and transform external reputation. Targeted interventions, data-led content strategy, and real-time performance monitoring delivered exceptional impact, major ranking gains of 165 places (target 50 places) and outstanding ROI. Demonstrating innovative, insight driven execution that exceeded every objective.

Let's hear from the judges

"The judges felt this was a great project with a clear aim and objectives, which were all met. Data and insights contributed to an improvement in institutional performance in QS rankings and to Aston's reputation."



Bronze Award

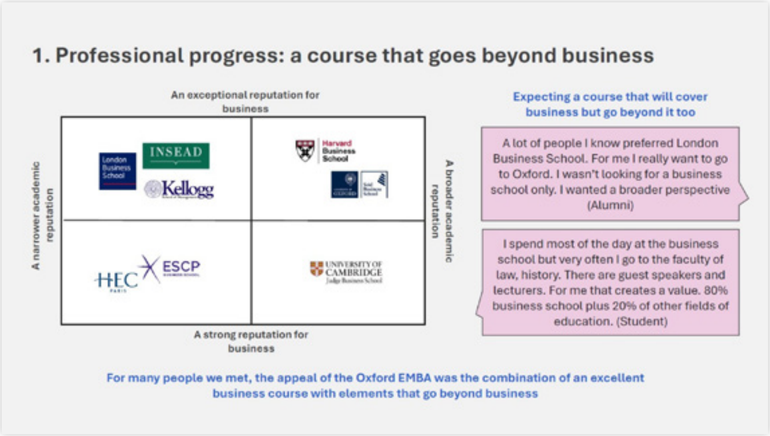
Saïd Business School, University of Oxford & Bray Leino

Repositioning the Oxford Executive MBA for Diversity and Growth

The Oxford Executive MBA's 'Enriched Minds' project used extensive quantitative and qualitative insights to successfully reposition the programme as a transformative, diverse leadership experience. Data-led and people-focused, it amplified authentic student voices across global channels, driving full enrolment, increased female participation and record engagement.

Let's hear from the judges

"The judges thought this was a strategically compelling and insight-rich submission tackling a genuinely challenging market, featuring outstanding use of qual and quant data across every stage of the funnel."



Best Community/Business Engagement Campaign

Sponsored by

THE HIDDEN 20%

Handed to the best campaign that engages with the local community, local businesses or the corporate community.

GOLD | SILVER | BRONZE

Gold Award

Best Community/Business Engagement Campaign

University of Lancashire

Lancashire Science Festival



Lancashire Science Festival 2025 transformed a university campus into a vibrant, inclusive celebration of curiosity, engaging over 9,000 people through free, immersive STEM experiences. Data-led and equity-driven, the festival over-represented deprived communities, inspired future scientists, and measurably shifted parental attitudes. It proved that community engagement can drive real social impact at scale.

Let's hear from the judges

"This ambitious festival initiative stood out for its ability to engage underrepresented communities at scale while firmly delivering against every objective it set out to achieve. Judges praised its data-driven approach, clear focus on inclusion and measurable impact, recognising it as a powerful example of community engagement that reached the audiences who could benefit most."

Best Community/Business Engagement Campaign

Silver Award

University of South Wales

University of South Wales Immersed Festival

'Immersed' is an annual civic-facing festival, led by USW, that connects students, staff, communities, local businesses, public bodies, charities and the creative industries through a shared thematic narrative. Collaborating with industry, students apply the knowledge and skills gained from their studies to engage in all facets of a live festival.

Let's hear from the judges

"The judges were impressed by the scale and creativity of this long-running festival, which successfully brought together students, businesses, charities and the wider community through a shared creative vision, while providing real-world learning opportunities. It met clear institutional objectives and had great impact on both the city and on students."



Bronze Award

Northumbria University, Newcastle

Working Well in Healthcare: Transformative Experiential Learning and Simulated Environments

Northumbria University's 'Working Well in Healthcare' campaign unites healthcare leaders, educators, providers and policymakers to tackle the NHS workforce crisis. This submission centres on the campaign's second event. It was rooted in primary research and amplified through a national partnership with National Health Executive to extend reach and influence the wider workforce debate.

Let's hear from the judges

"This campaign combined events, research and digital engagement to address a challenge of national importance. The judges commended its strong understanding of audience needs, effective partnership approach and ability to generate meaningful engagement while extending the conversation beyond the event itself."



Best Student or Alumni Engagement Initiative

Sponsored by

UCAS

Handed to the best campaign or initiative addressing an identifiable challenge or objective.

GOLD | SILVER | BRONZE

Gold Award

Best Student or Alumni Engagement Initiative

University of East London

Winter Appeal



UEL's inaugural Winter Appeal was a peer-led alumni fundraising campaign built around a symbolic £2 entry point. Delivered on just £100 in print spend, it secured 113 first-time donors across 15 countries - 151% of target - achieving a 571% ROI and establishing a scalable, annual festive giving tradition.

Let's hear from the judges

"This is a clear, well-structured campaign with a strong central idea. By lowering the barrier to giving, it made participation feel both accessible and inclusive, while its authentic peer-led approach successfully inspired new audiences to get involved. The judges praised the campaign's simplicity, effectiveness and highly impressive results."

Best Student or Alumni Engagement Initiative

Silver Award

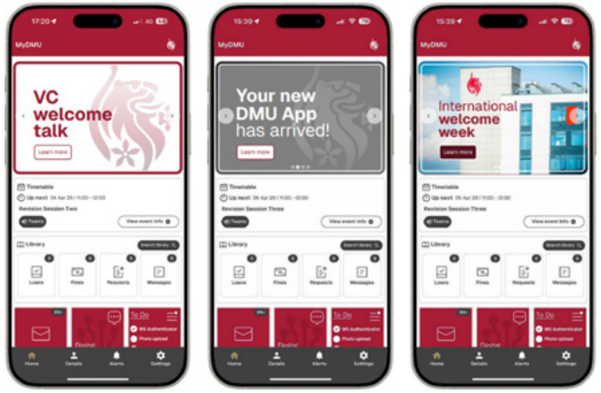
De Montfort University

myDMU App

myDMU is De Montfort University's redesigned student mobile and web app, created to strengthen engagement with current students throughout their academic journey. The aim was to reposition myDMU as the central engagement hub for campus life. It increased connection, belonging and support by delivering personalised accessible content in one, intuitive digital environment.

Let's hear from the judges

"This was a strong and well thought-through redevelopment of the DMU app, with a clear focus on improving engagement through personalisation, accessibility and co-creation with students. The use of student insight is particularly effective, with clear examples of how feedback directly shaped improvements."



Bronze Award

University of Westminster

Soho Poly Postcards Alumni Campaign

This nostalgic, elective print campaign re-engaged 1960s-70s Westminster alumni through a postcard offer linked to the University's refurbished Soho Poly theatre. By inviting alumni to update their details and reconnect through creative prompts, the campaign improved data accuracy and revived engagement. It also created a warm and responsive audience for future activities.

Let's hear from the judges

"A charming and nostalgic campaign that made a lasting impression on the judging panel, and successfully reconnected with a previously unengaged alumni audience. This initiative was a refreshing approach to alumni engagement - thoughtful, well-targeted and highly cost-effective."



Best Prospective Student Journey/Experience

Sponsored by



Handed to the best institution that offers an outstanding, consistent, and distinctive experience for every student, from engagement through to application and offer or decline.

GOLD | SILVER | BRONZE

Gold Award

Best Prospective Student Journey/Experience

University of East London

Choosing UEL - and Staying Chosen



UEL's summer Nurture Campaign tackled the growing challenge of 'mind changers' - accepted students who switch universities before enrolling. The campaign used data-driven, multi-channel engagement across emails, events, peer platforms and academic outreach. It raised enrolment conversion from 75% to 83%, generating £2.2m in additional tuition revenue from a £20,000 budget.

Let's hear from the judges

"This was a beautifully crafted, insight-led conversion campaign with exceptional use of data, innovative tactics and a genuine university-wide approach. It delivered outstanding outcomes across every metric. An exemplary submission, well done University of East London! "

Best Prospective Student Journey/Experience

Silver Award

Queen's University Belfast

From Awareness to Belonging: Supporting the Prospective Student on their Journey to Queen's University Belfast

Queen's identified a critical challenge: prospective students navigating a fragmented digital experience across their journey from awareness to enrolment. They created a unified digital student journey that met prospective students with the right content, on the right platform, at the right time - from first click to first day on campus.

Let's hear from the judges

"The judges thought this was a great redevelopment of the digital student journey. Using data across the whole project, it set out clear objectives and metrics and a forensic approach to improvements across different channels and platforms."



Bronze Award

LSE

From Discovery To Day One - Enhancing and Consolidating LSE's Undergraduate Student Journey

LSE transformed its undergraduate recruitment journey through a cohesive, digital-first strategy. Redesigned webpages, integrated touchpoints and data-driven email campaigns improved engagement, boosted lead generation and strengthened offer-holder conversion. The approach delivered sector-leading results, enhanced the student experience and created a seamless journey from first discovery to enrolment.

Let's hear from the judges

"The judges felt this was a strong submission demonstrating impressive end-to-end digital transformation across the prospective student journey, with excellent objective setting, solid outcomes and a notable achievement delivered by a small team."



Collaboration of the Year

Sponsored by



This award recognises outstanding collaborative efforts between institutions, departments, or external partners that have led to significant achievements.

GOLD | SILVER | BRONZE

Gold Award

Collaboration of the Year

Make Happen - Uni Connect

Bridgeway and Make Happen



The Bridgeway Homework Club is a collaborative programme between Make Happen and Bridgeway Mission supporting refugee learners facing disrupted education. Through tailored GCSE tuition, higher education workshops, mentoring and family engagement, it builds academic skills, confidence and aspirations. Importantly, it created sustainable pathways into further study and long-term community integration.

Let's hear from the judges

"This is a heartfelt and values-led collaboration, focused on a group of learners with very real barriers to education, belonging and progression. A worthy winner that demonstrates the true spirit of the category."

Collaboration of the Year

Silver Award

PingPong Digital, LNER X Universities

Learning on the line

The collaboration united LNER, UK universities and PingPong Digital to reposition rail as an integral part of the international student journey. By using LNER's university-connected routes as a storytelling framework, the campaign linked cities, campuses and lifestyle. It helped Chinese students visualise accessible, connected education across the UK beyond London.

Let's hear from the judges

"This is a creative and commercially smart collaboration, with a distinctive idea at its heart - using the LNER East Coast route as a storytelling spine to connect Chinese students and parents with regional UK university cities beyond London."



Bronze Award

WP Midlands Forum

Arden University, Nottingham Trent University, SIRM and University of Warwick

The WP Midlands Forum is jointly led by four universities. It has grown to support 120 widening participation practitioners across 28 institutions through a free best-practice network. By shaping events around member insight and sharing expertise, the collaboration strengthens regional practice, builds confidence and helps colleagues navigate sector challenges together.

Let's hear from the judges

"Co-led by Arden University, Nottingham Trent University, the University of Warwick and the University of Derby, this entry demonstrates true collaboration across institutions."



Rising Star Award

Sponsored by

CIM Higher & Further Education Group

Handed out in recognition of the best emerging talent in the industry, celebrating those who go above and beyond in their professional role.

GOLD | SILVER | BRONZE | HIGHLY COMMENDED

Gold Award

Rising Star Award

Kimberley Oshinowo

University of Huddersfield



In less than two years, Kimberley has transformed the University's website estate, playing a key role in the Coursefinder rebuild and website reskin while introducing automated course publishing, scalable components and WCAG-aligned accessibility. Her work improved performance, consistency and recruitment impact, reduced technical debt and reshaped internal practice.

Let's hear from the judges

"An exceptional early-career performer, Kimberley demonstrates a level of technical expertise, ownership and leadership well beyond expectations at this stage of her career. Through the delivery of complex, high-impact digital projects and her ability to influence institutional approaches, she has already created lasting change and established herself as a standout rising star with significant future potential."

Rising Star Award

Silver Award

Arjun Appadurai

University of East London

In under a year at UEL, Arjun transformed the university's creative output, conceiving cinema-ready campaigns, in-house. He produced a festive film that achieved 535,928 impressions and TikTok clicks 791% above target, saving over £50,000 in agency costs. Recognised sector-wide, he's redefining what early-career talent can achieve in higher education marketing.

Let's hear from the judges

"Arjun is an outstanding emerging talent whose creative ability, confidence and originality have already made a remarkable impact. Trusted to lead major projects and manage significant budgets at an early stage in his career, his talent and credibility have helped bring major campaign production in-house, strengthening capability, creating efficiencies and elevating creative standards across the institution."



Bronze Award

Kelsey Blemings

The University of Sheffield

In under three years at the University of Sheffield, Kelsey Blemings has transformed Schools Liaison into a high-performing, data-driven Lead Generation function. She has quintupled leads, embedded ROI, centralised Faculty strategy, and stepped into a significant leadership role. Kelsey combines commercial innovation with values-led culture, delivering structured, sustained institutional impact.

Let's hear from the judges

"Lead generation may not always grab the headlines, but judges recognised it as absolutely vital to recruitment success - and Kelsey has transformed how it is delivered at The University of Sheffield. Combining strategic thinking with strong leadership, she has driven meaningful cultural and operational change, influencing stakeholders across the organisation and establishing herself as a highly credible and impactful emerging leader."



Rising Star Award

Highly Commended

Alice Cimino

St Mary's University

With under two years' experience, Alice Cimino has gone beyond her role to transform the university's approach to social media. She has delivered sustained audience growth and introduced innovative ways of working. Importantly, Alice has also earned the trust and active buy-in of senior leaders through her judgement, professionalism and consistently high-impact results.

Let's Hear from the judges

"Alice has made an exceptional contribution in a remarkably short space of time. Through creativity, confidence and a natural understanding of audience engagement, she has helped reshape how content is created across the institution while delivering impressive results and growing influence."



Marketing Team of the Year

Sponsored by

HAVAS People
A Havas Company

Handed to the best overall FE or HE Marketing Team.

GOLD | SILVER | BRONZE | HIGHLY COMMENDED

Gold Award

Marketing Team of the Year

UWE Bristol



UWE Bristol's Marketing Team delivers bold, insight-led innovation that transforms recruitment and sector standards. From replacing the prospectus with a high-performing virtual tour to launching the UK's first AR city experience and pioneering ethical marketing, the team achieves exceptional impact, efficiency and engagement. This is a team that majors on collaboration, creativity and a values-driven strategy.

Let's hear from the judges

"This year's Marketing Team of the Year blew us away with their clear and innovative approach, perfectly embodying their brand through a strong and consistent narrative. From pioneering new ways for students to explore university life to delivering outstanding results across the entire recruitment journey, their exceptional balance of collaboration and team development truly sets a standard for excellence. Congratulations Team UWE! "

Marketing Team of the Year

Silver Award

Aston University

To deliver their ambitious new university strategy (target of +82% increase in students by 2030) Aston actively transformed their team. Previously underfunded and demotivated, they're now a truly high-performing team delivering a sector-leading brand and student recruitment growth. By developing an inclusive culture, they encouraged innovation and allowed everyone to shine.

Let's hear from the judges

"The judges were impressed by the team's clarity of purpose and the remarkable journey it has been on, underpinned by positive culture change and consistent achievement over time. Through a strong focus on capability, collaboration and performance, the team has transformed itself into a confident, strategically aligned driver of institutional growth."

Aston University
BIRMINGHAM UK

Bronze Award

London College of Contemporary Music

LCCM established a new four-person Marketing Team at a pivotal stage in the college's development - during a period of decisive brand renewal. The team defined and implemented a connection-led strategy, reshaping how LCCM presented itself. They ensured that its voice authentically reflected the identity and culture of its student community.

Let's hear from the judges

"Small but mighty, this team demonstrated what can be achieved when creativity, ambition and deep audience understanding come together. Judges were particularly struck by the scale of impact delivered by just four people, who are thinking, acting and performing like a 40-person department. Extremely impressive."



Marketing Team of the Year

Highly Commended

University of East London

UEL's Marketing Team is leading the sector with bold positioning, agency-standard creative delivery and against-the-grain recruitment growth. Through bold creative work, AI-readiness initiatives, and integrated campaigns like 'Think Again', they are championing higher education's value while achieving record rankings and results.

Let's hear from the judges

"Judges praised the UEL team's collaborative approach and laser focus on innovation, particularly its leadership in emerging technologies and AI. Delivering bold campaigns, high-quality content and impressive results, this team demonstrate how marketing can play a central role in driving institutional growth and reputation."



CONGRATULATIONS

TO ALL OF OUR 2026 WINNERS!

Thank you again for your entries
and we look forward to seeing you in 2027.

HEIST AWARDS '26